

38 MUHAMMAD RECEIVES THE DIVINE REVELATION

Muhammad's father-in-law, as caliph (successor) overcame the division within the Islamic community and this decision, together with a series of successful military campaigns against the malcontents, enabled the *umma* to survive.

Conquests beyond Arabia

Having secured their position, Muhammad's successors, in particular Umar (634–644), initiated campaigns of conquest further afield. They were fortunate in that profound changes had occurred on the northern fringes of Arabia. Between 602 and 628, the two long-established empires in the area—the Byzantines to the northwest

and the Persian Sassanids to the northeast—had been engaged in a long, vicious war that ended in catastrophe for both parties. Their coffers had been drained by the costs of the conflict and some regions within their territories had been utterly devastated. Both sides had also become reliant on Arabs to defend their borders and small, semi-independent Arab states had emerged on the peripheries of the two empires.

The Battle of Uhud (in 625) was one of several bloody conflicts fought between the Muslims of Medina, led by Muhammad, and the larger Qurayshi army from Mecca.

